

Recipe Authoring Standard

For K.'s Recipes — how Claude converts a link, PDF, or photo into app JSON

Version 1.0 · Applies to app v1.9.1 and later

The core rule

Nothing gets cut, measured, seasoned, or mixed once a pan is hot.

Source recipes almost universally interleave prep with cooking, because they're written by someone with a prepped station and no clock pressure. Followed literally by one person, that produces the exact failure we hit: mincing garlic while beef browns, hunting for cornstarch while the sauce should already be in the pan.

Every recipe is therefore restructured into three phases, in this order:

1. **PREP** — all knife work, all measuring, all seasoning, all sauces mixed
 2. **COOK** — heat only; every ingredient is already within arm's reach
 3. **ASSEMBLE** — plating and finishing
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The one permitted overlap

A long, **passive** process may start before prep if it meets *all four*:

- Needs zero attention for 5+ minutes once started
- Being late to it causes no harm
- It's the longest pole in the recipe
- It has its own timer

Rice, a preheating oven, water coming to a boil, a marinade, a brine. These start at step 1 and prep happens inside their window — that's not rushing, that's using dead time.

Never qualifies: anything in a skillet, anything that browns, anything where 60 seconds late means overcooked. If it can burn, it waits for prep to be finished.

Step construction

Phase labelling

Prefix step titles so the phase is obvious at a glance: `Prep — Slice the aromatics`, `Cook — Brown the beef`, `Serve — Build the bowls`.

Amounts

Every ingredient carries its **exact amount at the point of use**, in the step body. Not “add the garlic” — “add the 2 tsp minced garlic.” The ingredient list is for shopping; the step body is for cooking, and a cook reading step 9 should never have to scroll back.

Where a product brand was confirmed at the store, name it in the step too.

Coverage check

Every ingredient in the list appears in at least one step body with an amount. Every ingredient used in a step appears in the list. No exceptions — this is a mechanical check, run it.

A “ready check” step

The last prep step before heat is always a station check: everything measured, in bowls, beside the stove. It costs 30 seconds and it’s the step that makes the cook phase calm.

Timing fields

Two different fields, two different jobs. Don’t conflate them.

`approxSeconds` — hands-on time for the step

Goes on **every** step. Feeds the master clock’s schedule so the cook can see whether they’re ahead or behind. This is active working time, not elapsed time — a step that starts a 15-minute rice timer has `approxSeconds: 180`, because rinsing and setting it takes three minutes.

Estimate for one unhurried person who is not a professional. When in doubt, round up.

`timerSeconds` — a real physical process

Goes **only** on steps where something is cooking on a clock and being late has a cost. Rice

absorbing, beef searing, a sauce reducing, edamame steaming.

Rules:

- **Never** put a timer on a prep step. Prep is not a race, and a running timer manufactures the exact urgency we're eliminating.
 - For a range ("2–3 minutes"), use the **low end**. The timer should fire while there's still room to judge, not after the window closed.
 - If the step's timing is judged by eye or feel ("until fragrant"), no timer — put the cue in the body and the reasoning in the note.
 - A step may have `approxSeconds` without `timerSeconds` . Most do.
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Notes

The `note` field is for **why**, technique, and failure modes. It renders as a highlighted tip box.

Good: why rinsing jasmine matters, what a broken sauce looks like, what to do if it goes gluey, the substitution that changes the seasoning.

Not for: amounts or times that belong in the body. If a note is carrying an amount, the body is incomplete — fix the body.

Include at least one genuine flavor or efficiency tip per recipe beyond the source material.

Household defaults

- **Dairy-free.** Every dairy ingredient gets a substitute that actually works, technique-level if a product swap won't do it. Miyoko's is the default plant butter (best emulsification); Earth Balance as the fallback.
 - **Serves 4** unless told otherwise.
 - **Kroger, Indiana** sourcing. Verify a product exists before naming it.
 - Ingredient strings: `Product name, size (use amount)` .
 - Pantry items get a `- pantry` suffix, and anything that shouldn't generate a Kroger search link must be added to the app's `PANTRY` array.
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Ingredient string format

The app's parser strips parentheses and takes text before the first comma to build the Kroger search term. So:

- "Kikkoman Less Sodium Soy Sauce, 10 fl oz (use $\frac{1}{2}$ cup)" → searches *Kikkoman Less Sodium Soy Sauce*. Correct.
 - Avoid "X or Y" — the parser picks the **longer** string, which is rarely what you want. Name one product.
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Pre-delivery checklist

Run all of these before handing over JSON:

- JSON parses
- Three phases, in order, prefixed in titles
- No prep step occurs after the first heat step (except the permitted overlap)
- No prep step has a `timerSeconds`
- Every ingredient appears in a step body with an amount
- Every step has `approxSeconds`
- Timer ranges use the low end
- Total `time` field $\geq$ sum of `approxSeconds`, rounded up to a friendly number
- A ready check exists before the first heat step
- Dairy-free verified
- At least one added tip beyond the source